Prologue

Daughter of Two Worlds — before Chapter 1



Yara on the hidden perimeter at night, listening — Kijani glowing behind her.

A short opening, set later in the story.
Read this first. Then go back to the beginning,
and find out how she got here.

Series: Yara of Kijani
Book 1: Daughter of Two Worlds

Prologue

The jungle went quiet in the wrong place.

Yara stopped with one foot still raised. She had learned that quiet the hard way. The jungle was never truly silent — there were frogs, and dripping leaves, and small things moving in the dark where small things belonged. But this quiet was a hole in the sound, the shape of something big holding still inside it, the way the boar had held still on her first morning, being a tree so hard that it gave itself away.

She set her foot down without a sound, the way Zola had taught her, and breathed the way Amara had taught her. Slow. Low. Let the markings settle. The faint blue lines on her arms, already brightening with her heartbeat, dimmed again under her skin. Out here, past the last covered trail, light was a mistake. Oya had said it on the temple steps, and she said it every day after: no light leaves this place.

Then she listened with everything she had.

Water, to her left, over stone. A frog, far off, thinking better of it. Her own blood, too loud. And under it all, so faint she nearly missed it, a smell that did not belong to the green place at all.

Oil. Cleaned metal. Leather that had been treated in a factory, not cured in smoke. And human sweat — not Vey'kar sweat, which ran sharp and green like cut leaves, but the other kind. The kind she half was.

Her hand found the knife at her belt by itself. Her fingers tightened on the hilt, then eased again, and her markings dimmed as she breathed out, slow.

Her lips barely moved. “Not an animal,” she whispered, to no one. She swallowed, angry at the fear in her own voice. Animals did not smell of oil.

She moved the way the trail itself moved, a few steps at a time, stopping between the roots, letting the dark settle back around her after each step. The smell grew stronger near the place where the covered trail bent — the trail her mother erased every single time, dragging branches across soft earth, pressing leaves back into place, leaving jungle and only jungle behind.

Yara crouched. The moon gave her almost nothing under the canopy, but she did not need much. A hunter reads the ground with fingers as much as eyes.

The drag marks were there. She could feel their shallow lines.

And pressed down straight through them, deep in the wet earth, was a boot print.

It was not a Vey'kar print. No one in Kijani wore boots. It was not an old print either — its edges were still sharp, and no rain had softened it yet. A heavy man, by the depth of it. A careful man, by where he had put his weight, out at the edge of the trail, where someone who did not want to be followed would walk.

Three steps further on, she found the second print. That one was full of dark water, its edges already crumbling. Older. Days older.

He had not found the trail once, by luck.

He had come back.

The thought settled in her chest like something swallowed wrong. Once could be a lost man, wandering. Twice was a hunter, returning to a trail he meant to use again — and Yara knew, with a cold, clear certainty that made her fingers numb around the knife, that he would come a third time.

Above her head, something clicked.

Yara froze. It was a small sound, neat and mechanical, nothing like a beak or a claw or a branch giving way. Slowly, she raised her face. Strapped to the trunk at head height, wrapped in bark cloth someone had taken care to match to the tree, was a dark box with a glass eye. As she watched, deep inside the glass, a tiny red light blinked once — patient, fed, and awake.

It was a camera. It had been watching the trail. Watching everyone who used the trail. Watching, perhaps, her.

Yara’s mouth went dry. She did not move, though every part of her wanted to — to climb, to tear it down, to run. One hand had pressed flat against the trunk without her deciding it, the bark damp and rough under her palm. How many nights, she thought. How many of us has it seen? Her stomach turned over, slow and cold.

Slowly, she lifted her other hand toward the box — not to touch, not quite, her fingers trembling in the dark.

Oya did not move, or look down at Yara. Her voice was low and flat, with all the feeling pressed down hard underneath it. “Do not touch it.”

Oya's voice came out of the dark so close behind her that Yara's markings flared before she could stop them. Her mother stood between the roots with no light on her at all, and Yara had not heard her come — she never did. Oya was looking not at Yara, and not at the prints, but up at the glass eye, and her face was doing something Yara had never seen it do before.

Her mother was afraid. Not for herself. Yara understood that in the same instant, the way she sometimes understood people before they spoke. For all of it. For the temple and the tree shelters and the twenty souls sleeping behind them, who believed the green place would keep them.

Yara let her raised hand fall to her side. She looked at her mother, steadied her breathing, and tried again, quieter. “How long?” Yara asked quietly. She swallowed, her throat tight, her markings brightening in spite of her. “How long has he been watching us?”

Oya reached out, very slowly, and closed her hand around Yara's wrist — not hard, just certain, the way she had held it as a child at the edge of high places.

Oya was quiet for a long moment. Something tired, and guilty, moved behind her calm — there, and gone — and she did not look at Yara as she answered. “Long enough,” she said, “to learn the way in.” Her thumb pressed once against Yara’s wrist, and stilled.

Behind them, far below through the trees, the shielded fires of Kijani burned small and steady, the way they always did, as if nothing in the world could find them.

Oya let go of her wrist and turned to face her. Her markings, dark all this time, brightened just a little — enough for Yara to see her face plainly: worried, and trying hard not to show how much. “Go and wake Jabari,” Oya said. Her voice dropped lower, and she waited for Yara’s small, shaky nod before she went on. “Quietly. And Yara — from tonight, no one walks the green place alone.”

Yara nodded again, not trusting her voice, and turned toward the fires below, feeling the glass eye at her back.

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Where this sits: This prologue happens later in Book 1, after Yara has been in Kijani for some time. Chapter 1, “The Green Place,” goes back to the beginning — the morning Yara came to live in Kijani — and the story builds, chapter by chapter, toward this night.